

sa

ISSUE 1 2025

Homeschooling *and beyond*

BEYOND THE MAINSTREAM

The rise of alternative
schooling options in SA

Alternatives to matric

Student-
targeted
scams

Advantages
of early
childhood
education

THE IMPORTANCE OF
CAREER GUIDANCE

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2025

4-TERM SCHOOLS

August

Sunday	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday
					1	2
3	4 Maths	5 Eng	6 Afr	7 LS LO	8 LS CA	9
10	11	12 Robot Soc.Sci	13 Nat. Sci &Tech	14 Tech	15 Gen.Kn Bible S	16
17	18 E.M.S	19 Robot	20	21	22	23

2025

3-TERM SCHOOLS

September

Sunday	Monday	Tuesday	Wednesday	Thursday	Friday	Saturday
	1 Maths	2 Eng	3 Afr	4 LS LO	5 LS CA	6
7	8 Robot Soc.Sci	9 Nat. Sci &Tech	10 Tech	11 Gen.Kn Bible S	12 E.M.S	13
14	15 Robot	16	17	18	19	20



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2025, here we go! It's wonderful to be back at the *SA Homeschooling & Beyond* headquarters and we look forward to continue sharing support resources, skills and expert advice with you to help you on your homeschooling journey.

I love what a new year symbolises: fresh starts and new possibilities. It's an opportunity to set new goals and forge a new path forward. It allows us to evaluate what worked for us during last year and purge ourselves of the attitudes and habits that didn't.

This year our eldest child, Erik, will be in Grade 5 and our daughter, Kaylin, in Grade 4. Our youngest,

Phillip, turned five in January. I can't believe how quickly the previous year flew by. I've always been over-ambitious when it comes to new year's resolutions, so rather than setting myself up to fail, I'm limiting myself to just three attainable goals.

I'm not going to compare myself with other moms. It's important to remind ourselves that everybody's motherhood journey is different so that we can be happy for other moms' successes instead of feeling guilty about our own strengths as mothers.

Getting out of my comfort zone is intimidating, but this year, I'm going to try something new,

whether it's learning to sew, joining a rebounding class or start to play tennis again.

Finally, nobody likes saying "no", but in reality, you can't do it all. I realise that for my own sanity, "no" must be part of my vocabulary. I need to prioritise my time and what's truly important.

May every day of 2025 be filled with joy and happiness for you and your family! Please be in touch with us, as your unique journey also inspire others.

Happy reading!

Adri



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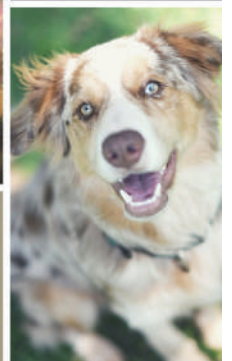


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sa Homeschooling *and beyond*

Dalena will answer any type of questions, concerns or issues you may have about learning, concentration, memory, cognitive development and of course, frustrations and problems you may have with these.

**PARENTS, E-MAIL
YOUR QUESTIONS TO**

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ASK DALENA



According to KLA's YouGov Profiles, 56% of parents with children younger than 18 believe that state school education isn't up to standard. Pupils in the poorest 70% of schools are now 10 times less likely to read for meaning than the wealthiest 10%, highlighting a widening educational gap and growing dissatisfaction with public education. This is encouraging parents to seek alternative forms of education.

Homeschooling in SA is regulated under the SA Schools Act (SASA) and the Home Education Policy, allowing parents to register their child for home education. Parents must choose a curriculum, ensure regular assessments and keep records of the child's academic progress. However, with these responsibilities comes the flexibility to design a learning programme tailored to the child's needs, promoting individual growth and critical thinking.



The rise of alternative schooling options in SA

In South Africa, the traditional schooling model is experiencing a shift, with an increasing number of families opting for non-traditional education options such as homeschooling and online schooling, writes Rakhee Naik, Managing Consultant at KLA. This trend is driven by a variety of factors, including the rising costs of private schooling, a desire for more flexibility, safety and concerns about the quality of government education

Online schooling has been driven by technological advancements and the need for flexible learning options. Many institutions have played a key role in shaping online education trends, offering curricula that cater to a wide range of pupils. This flexible approach allows pupils to learn at their own pace, while still

benefiting from a structured educational programme provided by qualified teachers.

The 60% of parents with children younger than 18 who agree that many things they learnt in traditional school are irrelevant to life may find online schooling appealing, as it provides the





opportunity to incorporate real-world skills into the curriculum. In addition, online schooling reduces the need for expensive private schooling, which is a barrier for many families.

Although YouGov Profiles shows that 80% of parents with children younger than 18 believe that private schools provide the best opportunities (this is higher than the national South African population), 68% of them also feel that private schools are elitist, leading parents to explore more inclusive alternatives.

Homeschooling provides a less stressful environment, free from the pressures of bullying and fitting in – a welcome reality, since 60% of South African children need mental health support. It allows flexibility in scheduling that promotes better sleep, productivity and overall well-being.

Additionally, 82% of parents believe that schools should encourage sports and the homeschooling and online learning adaptable structure can support this by offering more time for physical activity, helping children thrive academically, emotionally and physically.

Despite the benefits, however, non-traditional schooling also comes with challenges. Parents must ensure that the chosen curriculum meets academic standards and is recognised by higher education institutions,



while also complying with regulations, such as independent assessments and government oversight. Furthermore, homeschooled children may have limited social interactions and lack exposure to diverse perspectives and experiences.

Looking ahead, it's clear that alternative schooling models are here to stay. The combination of personalised learning, flexibility and technological advancements like artificial intelligence and learning analytics will likely continue to shape the future of education in SA.

In conclusion, non-traditional schooling in South Africa offers families a range of choices that cater to different educational philosophies, learning styles and practical needs. Whether through homeschooling, online schooling or hybrid models, the focus on the clear benefits possible presents new opportunities for children to thrive.

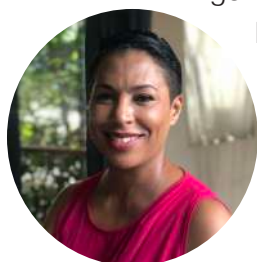
“The combination of personalised learning, flexibility and technological advancements will likely continue to shape the future of education in SA.”



Getting kids back on track with their school routine



Just like that, the holidays are over and most South African pupils must return to their school routines. Lianne Williams, Marketing Director at Vuma, shares helpful tips that parents and guardians can use to help pupils overcome the back-to-school blues and make the most of the new academic year



While some children might be thrilled to start the new school year, others might be overwhelmed. As a result, they lack the drive to tackle the work.

Here's how to help your child overcome the back-to-school blues and make the most of the new academic year, says Williams:

1 Give them something to look forward to: Whether it's a fun after-school activity or a holiday at the end of the term, having something exciting to look forward to is a great way to keep pupils' spirits up throughout the day. It could even be a trip to their favourite restaurant for dinner, tickets to an upcoming concert or show, or a surprise gift they're sure to love.

2 Encourage healthy living: No one wants to wake up early in the morning after less than eight hours of sleep the previous night, so ensure that your child gets to bed at a reasonable hour. Also encourage them to eat more veggies and fruit and avoid sugary drinks, caffeine and junk food, to help set them up for happier, more energised days.

3 Make life and learning easier: Unlike previous generations, Gen-Zs don't have to go through several study materials to conduct research on topics of their interest. The Internet has streamlined studying, making it less time-consuming by empowering pupils with access to the latest digital education



resources. However, having an unreliable Internet connection can do more harm than good, hindering rather than helping them with their academic needs.

“A pupil would sooner give up than wait forever for a tutorial video to buffer,” says Williams, Marketing Director at SA’s largest fibre network operator, Vuma. “Removing the barriers to learning by investing in a reliable, fast fibre connection for the home can change a child’s life. I encourage parents to look into this, as it changes the way children learn in their homes.”

4 Get organised:

The saying, “When you fail to plan, you plan to fail”, couldn’t be truer for pupils. Get them a large calendar that they can stick on the wall to plan upcoming tasks and deadlines, including test and exam dates, study blocks and rest days. Alternatively, you

can download online tools such as Todoist, which allows users to add tasks and categorise them by due date and priority, or Google Workspace, which includes Google Calendar, Google Docs and Google Drive. Staying organised is half the battle won when trying to get back into the swing of things.



5 Remove distractions:

Without becoming too restrictive and “punishing” your child, it’s important to remove things from their weekday activities that may become too distracting from their studies. These include constant use of digital devices and social media, gaming consoles, late nights out with friends and even binge-watching TV shows. Some pupils may pretend to use their devices to consume educational content when they’re actually engaging with friends online or catching up on series. Installing apps such as StayFocusd can help restrict the time they spend on distracting apps.



The importance of career guidance



Many students reach senior high school, or even matric and beyond, without knowing what career they'd like to pursue. This is why early career guidance is vital during the early high school years – firstly, to determine a pupil's passion and purpose and then to align their high school path to future qualification opportunities

According to Dr Bronwyn Batchelor, Head of Faculty: Law at the Independent Institute of Education, South Africa's leading private higher education provider, career guidance is crucial during the early high school years, as

it not only helps to determine a pupil's passion and purpose, but also aligns their high school path to future qualification opportunities. This allows them to make strategic – rather than ill-informed – education and career choices that will set them up for success throughout their academic journey and the world of work.

“While many parents and guardians adopt a ‘wait-and-see’ approach, the reality is that insufficient early exposure to relevant career guidance puts pupils at risk of making misinformed education and career choices,” she says.

She adds that having a clear idea of their general future direction helps pupils establish the path towards a meaningful career, as well as find purpose in their school studies.



“Once you know what qualifications will be required for your future career field, you can ensure that you pursue the correct subjects and perform in line with the entry requirements at higher education institutions.

“For example, if you want to enter a legal career and ultimately become a lawyer – whether an attorney or an advocate – it’s important to know that the only qualification which allows this progress is the Bachelor of Laws (LLB) degree. Pupils who aren’t adequately informed may incorrectly believe that they can enter a legal career with a Bachelor of Commerce in Law or a Bachelor of Arts in Law. Although these degrees allow further progression and articulation to a Bachelor of Laws (LLB) degree, only the Bachelor of Laws (LLB) degree would allow ultimate entry into the legal profession.”

Staying with the legal example, pupils who aspire to run their own law firm and have been

“Career guidance normally begins with an assessment of a pupil’s skills, interests and strengths.”



given proper guidance will know that it may be necessary to opt for a longer study route to ensure that they obtain all the necessary entrepreneurial, business, management and legal subject matter expertise. This could include completing a Bachelor of Commerce in Law first and then pursuing a Bachelor of Law.

“A career is more than just a job; it’s a lifetime pursuit that provides fulfilment, purpose and financial stability. The importance of choosing a career lies in its ability to provide direction and focus for your life goals and aspirations,” says Batchelor.

“In high school, pupils are often only aware of the popular and common career choices or those with which their social circle or family are associated, whereas there are many more career opportunities in today’s working world, with the list growing daily.”

Career guidance normally begins with an assessment of a pupil’s skills, interests and strengths. This information is then used to identify potential career paths that may be a good fit. A career counsellor may provide information about various occupations, such as job requirements, growth potential and earning potential. They may also help pupils explore education and training options and offer advice on how to gain relevant work experience.

“I therefore encourage pupils to make an appointment with a counsellor as early in their high school education as possible to ensure that they’re fully equipped to make subject choice decisions that align with the entry requirements into the qualification they need to fulfil their academic and career aspirations,” says Batchelor.



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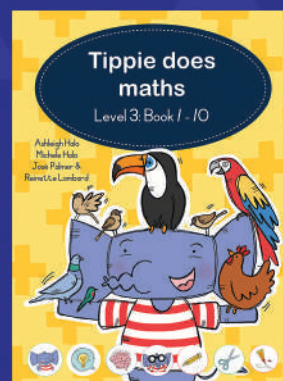
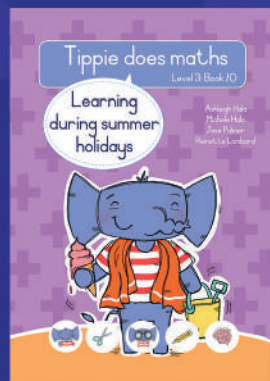
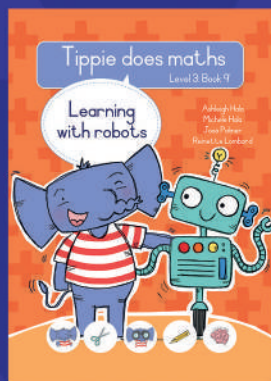
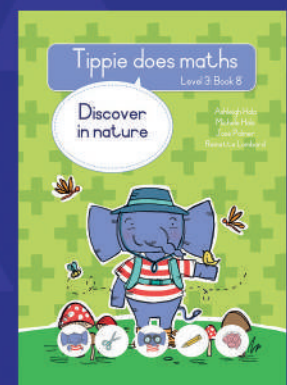
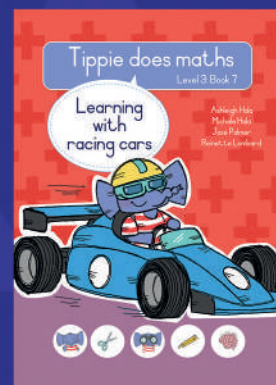
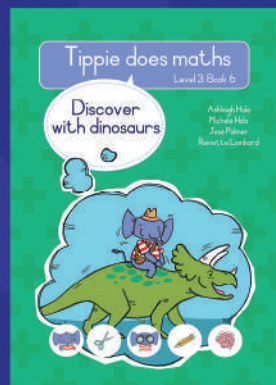
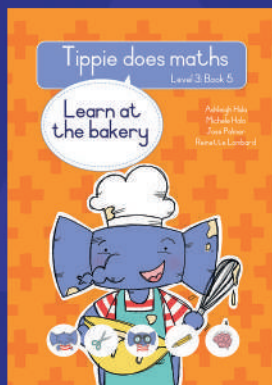
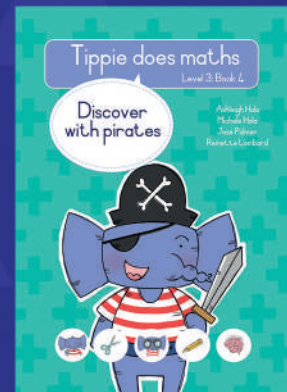
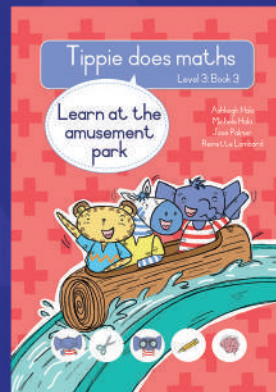
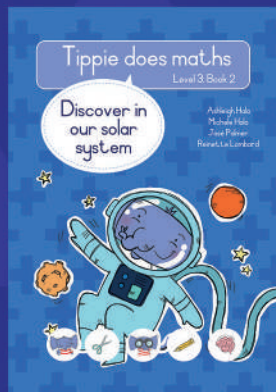
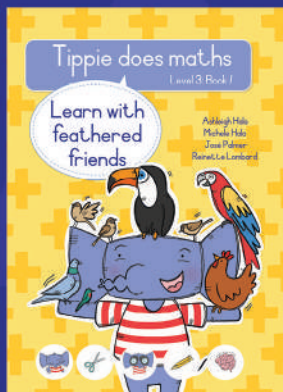
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How online schools in SA are preparing students for tertiary education

A persistently high percentage of students drop out before completing their tertiary degrees, or don't obtain them within the allotted time. In looking for solutions to the country's "dropout crisis", there's an increasing focus on what schools are doing to better prepare students for the transition.

"It's possible for a high school to deliver an education and even achieve good matric marks, but not equip its students sufficiently for tertiary education and the real world. The problem isn't just that the work gets harder, but that many high schools aren't bridging the gap in terms of higher-order thinking and responsibility skills," says Mark Anderson, Principal and co-founder of Koa Academy, South Africa's leading high-engagement online school.

Learning how to think critically

Many traditional schools focus on memorisation and repetition, providing only a basic understanding of concepts, and this is what Anderson refers to as lower-order thinking. It leads pupils to believe that there's one right answer for every question and all they need to do is memorise that one right answer. However, forward-thinking high schools are

focusing on the development of critical thinking skills such as analysis, evaluation and interpretation of data, which are more nuanced and challenging ways of learning content.

“If I teach you how to think critically, how to evaluate information and construct a good argument, you’re not going to necessarily know the answer to a particular question, but you’ll have the thinking skills to solve the problem. So, if you’re adept at higher-order thinking, then you can go into an exam, see a question you’ve never seen before and, instead of being stumped, use your higher-order thinking skills to answer it. It’s much more practically applicable to real-life situations, where you aren’t going to be able to memorise the answers to everything. In real life, most questions don’t have one specific, correct answer,” explains Anderson.

Learning how to manage yourself A second aspect of tertiary studies that new students stumble over is what Anderson calls “the personal responsibility gap”. “Managing yourself and your work competently is a foundational expectation when you get to university. However, in traditional high school settings, parents and teachers take too much responsibility on behalf of the pupil for too long. A simple example of this is a teacher having to walk their matric class through how to set up an effective study timetable. That’s



“Many high schools aren’t bridging the gap in terms of higher-order thinking and responsibility skills.”



too late in the game. Kids need to be learning self-organising skills at a much younger age. There needs to be a higher degree of ownership that’s age-appropriate as pupils progress through the school years,” he says.

How to build tertiary-ready skills in online classrooms

Anderson believes that preparing students well for tertiary education isn’t inherent in either traditional or online schooling models. Some traditional schools do a great job at tertiary-preparedness, as do some online schools – but both models can come up short if they’re not focusing on developing the skills crucial to succeeding at university or college.

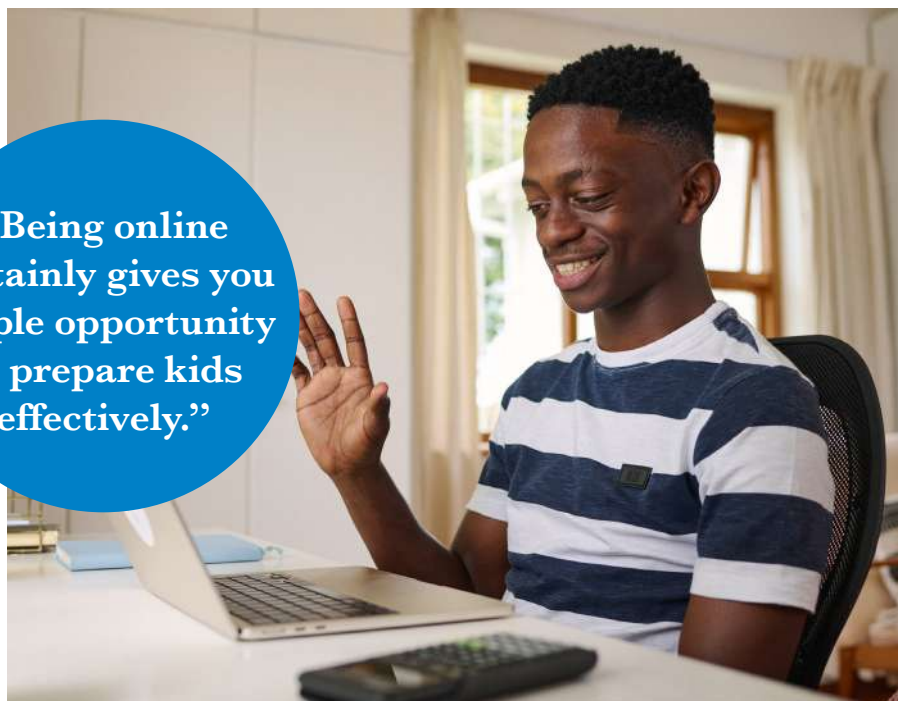


“However, being online certainly gives you ample opportunity to prepare kids effectively. At Koa Academy for example, we’re intentionally focused on leveraging these rich opportunities to ensure not only that pupils are fit for tertiary education, but that they’re getting a school education which also sets them up for success in today’s world of work,” he says.

Online school needs a healthy balance of guided and self-paced work. There needs to be sufficient, meaningful teacher engagement so that pupils aren’t thrown into the deep end and expected to self-study their way through high school. This must be blended with self-paced work which empowers pupils to take control of their own work, set their own rhythms and be accountable for their deliverables and deadlines.

Here are Anderson’s three top questions for parents to ask when assessing an online school’s capacity for university preparedness:

“Being online certainly gives you ample opportunity to prepare kids effectively.”



- Who is the school registered with? You need to know the exam body that will assess Grade 12 and ensure that your values are aligned with those of both the school and its accreditation body.



- Ask the school to describe the types of interactions pupils have with the teachers and how often these happen. What size are the groups that they will participate in?

- How does the school maintain accountability in the online space? What tools does it have in place to show that your child will be held accountable in an age-appropriate way?

“I also advise parents whose kids are starting to think about tertiary studies to be curious before they’re convinced about their child’s future. It’s important to ask lots of questions, to really listen deeply to your child and then be open to the answers. Modern careers are no longer linear, as they were when we parents were pupils ourselves and were choosing study and career paths.”



Top seven advantages of early childhood care and education

Early childhood education is the cornerstone of a child's development, laying the groundwork for lifelong learning and success.

"Early childhood education goes beyond preparing children for school – it sets them up for life," says Ursula Assis, Country Director of Dibber International Preschools. "It's about fostering essential skills, building confidence and inspiring a lifelong love of learning."

Assis shares the key benefits of early education:

1 Literacy and numeracy skills: Early exposure to letters, numbers and foundational concepts equips children with essential tools for academic success.

2 Socialisation: Interaction with peers nurtures empathy, co-operation and the value of community.



3 Independence: Stepping into a structured preschool environment helps children develop problem-solving abilities and confidence.

4 Confidence: Feeling seen and heard in a supportive setting boosts self-esteem and encourages self-expression.

5 Routine and structure: Predictable daily routines provide stability and teach essential life skills, such as time management.

6 Lifelong love of learning: A positive, engaging learning environment nurtures curiosity and a thirst for knowledge.

7 Exposure to diversity: Children gain an appreciation for diverse cultures, abilities and backgrounds, fostering respect and inclusivity.



SCAM!

Staying safe this new academic year

Scammers are becoming increasingly sophisticated, exploiting the trust and urgency often associated with the need to secure study placement, accommodation, etc. Students are particularly vulnerable, as they may be unfamiliar with common scams or eager to secure deals quickly, amid tough competition for limited space and resources, says Adrian Garden, Acting Dean of Academics at the Independent Institute of Education's Rosebank College

Bogus institutions
Bogus colleges prey on the desperation of prospective students who didn't secure a spot at their preferred institution of higher learning, or those with limited financial means.

Unfortunately, signing up with a bogus institution means that you'll waste precious time and money, with nothing to show for your efforts. Any credible tertiary institution must be able



to show you a certificate to that effect, which details the campus, provider and qualifications. All higher education qualifications need to be accredited by the Higher Education Quality

Committee of the Council on Higher Education. If they aren't accredited, they won't appear on the certificate referred to above.

All qualifications also need to be registered on the National Qualifications Framework (NQF) by the SA Qualifications Authority (SAQA) and students should ask for the SAQA NQF identity numbers.

Logistical scams

Scammers targeting students also focus on all areas of the

value chain, such as offering rooms or other accommodation, transport services, second-hand textbook sales, etc.

Scammers target individuals on both sides of the transaction, leveraging common vulnerabilities. Common factors that attract them include:

- **Eager buyers:** Students may rush to secure deals on textbooks, electronics or household items at discounted rates, making them prime targets for fake listings.

- **Trusting sellers:** Students selling items such as gaming consoles, laptops or textbooks may be eager to conclude a deal, unknowingly falling victim to fraudulent buyers.

- **High-value items:** Transactions involving popular items like technological devices, luxury accessories or event tickets are particularly at risk.

- **Urgency and emotional stories:** Scammers often create urgency or share emotional stories, such as buying something for a loved one, to gain trust and pressurise victims into quick decisions.

“Scammers often accept the price immediately or offer extra money for shipping or courier fees. Sellers may also present fake shipping confirmations, while buyers may



provide fake payment notifications, such as SMS alerts,” says Garden.

“Scammers may also use couriers who aren’t linked to reputable companies, claiming that they can’t deliver or pay until additional money is sent. If there are any sudden changes to agreed terms, such as payment methods or delivery details, you may be on the receiving end of a common scam tactic.”



Garden says that students are especially vulnerable to scammers due to urgency and limited time as the new academic year kicks off. However, they should always err on the side of caution. “Verify the product or service and demand secure payment options on above-board platforms,” he emphasises.

Perhaps most important of all, if a handover needs to happen, choose meeting points in safe public areas, he says.

“Don’t let buyers rush or manipulate you into completing a deal. Scammers often create urgency to bypass your safeguards. For instance, when applying to an institution or purchasing academic materials, student support centres at quality higher education institutions will be happy to assist and guide you.”

“Students are especially vulnerable to scammers due to urgency and limited time as the new academic year kicks off.”

Ask Dalena



Dalena van der Westhuizen will answer any questions or concerns you may have about learning, concentration, memory and cognitive development – and, of course, the frustrations arising from these

What are the most important things to consider when choosing subjects in Grade 10, especially if I'm unsure of what I want to study one day, or whether I even want to study at all? – Thomas Krieger

Hi Thomas

Consider consulting a professional in subject choices and career guidance to understand the workload and career possibilities linked to each subject.

If you're unsure about your future plans, the best approach is always to keep your options open while playing to your strengths. Choose a balanced combination that will give you multiple pathways to choose from.

For example, keeping mathematics (rather than mathematical literacy) and physical science can help if you later decide on engineering, medicine or IT. If you enjoy business, consider accounting or business studies. Subjects like life

sciences, geography or IT can be useful across different fields, even if you don't pursue a degree.

Also, consider practical skills. If you enjoy working with your hands, subjects like engineering graphics and design or consumer studies could be useful. If you're leaning towards entrepreneurship, business studies, bookkeeping or economics might help.

Above all, choose subjects you enjoy and can excel in, as this will make learning more enjoyable and keep doors open for the future.

I've been homeschooling my child since Grade 1, as we live on a farm quite far from any town. My child will be going to high school next year and will need to be in boarding school. What are important things to consider when choosing a school? – Dalene Goddard

Hi Dalene

Moving from homeschooling to boarding school is a big transition, so choosing the right school is important for both academic success and emotional well-being. Start





by looking at the curriculum – does the school follow a similar academic structure to what your child’s used to? If your child has studied in a self-paced or discussion-based way, a school with smaller classes and interactive teaching may be a better initial fit than one with a rigid, high-pressure system.

Next, consider the school’s boarding facilities. A good boarding school should offer a structured, but supportive environment. Ask about mentorship, emotional support and how new pupils are helped to settle in.

If your child will be staying in over weekends, find out about weekend activities. Some schools keep pupils busy with events and outings, while others allow more free time.

Social dynamics also matter, so ask about the school’s values and how it handles discipline, friendships and homesickness.

If possible, visit these schools with your child and talk to current boarders about their experiences.

When you’ve completed your visit to all the prospective schools available to you, be sure to ask your child for their opinion on which one would be the best fit.

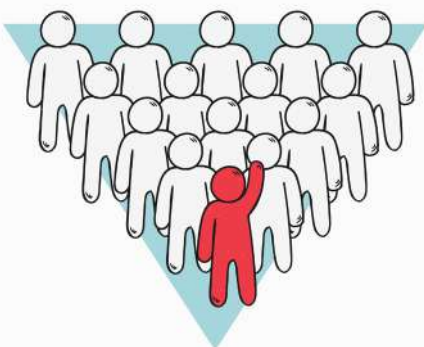
As the parent of a home-schooler, how do I encourage my child to develop leadership skills? – Rose Coertzen

Hi Rose

Leadership skills develop through practice and responsibility. Encourage your child to take charge of projects, whether in academics, sports, your home or hobbies. Provide opportunities for decision-making and problem-solving in daily life.

Start by encouraging independent projects: let your child plan a family event, manage their own study schedule or take responsibility for a specific task.

Look for opportunities outside the home, too. Many homeschool networks have student committees, debating clubs or



entrepreneurial programmes where kids can develop leadership skills. If possible, involve your child in volunteering – helping at an animal shelter, organising a community clean-up or tutoring younger children all build leadership qualities.

The key is (regularly) creating opportunities where they can lead, make mistakes, learn and grow.



About Dalena

Dalena van der Westhuizen is the co-founder and MD of BrainAbility, a cognitive development specialist, a master brain coach and an internationally certified cognitive coach. She translates the latest international cognitive research and best practice into strategies that can be applied by parents and educators alike.

A mom and a self-confessed chocoholic, Dalena enjoys working with both kids and adults to improve the way their brains process information for better learning, reading and focusing.

Send your questions
for Dalena to:
adri@isikhova.co.za.

Tasty, cheesy potato muffins*Preparation time: 12 mins**Cooking time: 30 mins***Ingredients:**

8 large potatoes peeled, boiled and mashed (Mom can help if kids are still young)

250ml (1 cup) grated Cheddar cheese

1 large egg, beaten

60ml (4T) finely chopped chives

60ml (4T) self-raising flour

2,5ml (½ tsp) garlic powder

120ml (¾ cup) finely grated Parmesan cheese

8 pieces fried bacon, cut into small pieces

Spray and Cook

Salt and pepper to taste

What else you will need:

A medium-sized pot

A potato peeler

A medium-sized mixing bowl

A grater

A potato masher

A chopping board

A spoon

A frying pan

1 x muffin pan



Easy dinner recipes that kids can make

Chef and mom of four Anri Fourie shares three simple, family-friendly recipes that are the perfect way to get your kids cooking

**Method:**

1. Pre-heat oven to 200°C.
2. Spray the muffin pan with Spray and Cook.
3. Mix the mashed potatoes with the Cheddar cheese, chives, flour, garlic powder, bacon, salt and pepper
4. Add the egg and blend well.
5. Shape the mixture into 12 even round balls.
6. Roll (coat) the potato balls with Parmesan cheese and press into the muffin cups.
7. Bake for 15-20 mins, until the edges are golden-brown.
8. Serve with a green salad.



Pilchard fish cakes

Preparation time: 15 mins

Cooking time: 20 mins

Ingredients:

- 1 x 400g canned pilchards (tomato flavour)
- 2 slices brown bread, crumbed
- 1 egg, beaten
- 1 large onion, finely chopped (Mom can help with chopping if kids are still young)
- 1 handful parsley, chopped
- 2 carrots, finely grated
- Salt and pepper to taste
- Oil

What else you will need:

- A medium-sized mixing bowl
- A spatula
- A frying pan
- A fork
- A grater



Method:

1. Drain the pilchards, leaving a little sauce.
2. Mix with the rest of the ingredients.
3. Form the mixture into small, round, flat patties.
4. Fry in pan with a little oil for approximately 3 minutes on each side, until brown and crispy.



5. Drain excess oil on paper towel and serve with mashed potatoes and a green salad.

Cream cheese pasta

Preparation time: 15 mins

Cooking time: 45 mins

Ingredients:

- 500g cherry tomatoes
- 1 red onion, chopped
- 2 garlic cloves, crushed
- 60ml (4T) olive oil
- 250g smooth cream cheese in the flavour of your choice
- 1 packet of streaky bacon, cut into cubes and fried until crispy
- 300g pasta of your choice
- 60ml (4T) fresh basil, finely chopped
- 100g baby spinach leaves

- 1 red pepper, cut in small cubes

Salt and pepper to taste

What else you will need:

- A large baking dish
- A frying pan
- A large pot
- A knife
- A big spoon

Method:

1. Pre-heat oven to 200°C.
2. Place tomatoes, onions, garlic and olive oil in a large baking dish.
3. Season with salt and pepper and mix together.
4. Once mixed, add cream cheese and bacon and mix well.
5. Bake for 30 minutes.
6. While the mixture is baking, cook the pasta in a large pot as per packet instructions.
7. Drain the water from the pot, reserving 150ml (¾ cup) of it.
8. Remove the dish from the oven and mix well. Mash the tomatoes with a fork.
9. Stir in the 150ml of pasta water.
10. Add spinach and basil
11. Add pasta, mix thoroughly and serve with a green salad.



Anri Fourie, owner of two guesthouses and mom of a nine-year-old daughter and five-year-old triplets, cooks meals that are quick and easy to make – with multiple little helping hands. In the Fourie household, family time is a great time to cook together. As the former owner of a coffee shop, Anri used to share the kitchen with skilled chefs. Today she shares it with her four busy little offspring, who're all eager to pitch in and help.

Alternatives to matric

In South Africa, a matric certificate is still considered the gold standard for educational achievement and the ticket to further study. However, it's important to recognise that this path may not be the best fit for everyone and that there are alternative routes to career success

"For many pupils, the rigours and constraints of the senior high journey and matric can be daunting and the pressure to perform can be overwhelming. However, this doesn't mean that these individuals are devoid of potential or that they lack the skills and dedication required to succeed in their chosen careers," says Siyavuya Makubalo, Marketing Manager at Oxbridge Academy, a brand of Africa's leading private education provider ADVTECH.

"This leaves these students and their parents in despair, particularly if they're not aware of the options available to them outside of matric completion," she says.

The reality is that SA offers a robust alternative to the matric route through SAQA-registered occupational certificates.

These qualifications, registered with the SA Qualifications Authority (SAQA) and quality

assured by the Quality Council for Trades and Occupations (QCTO), are designed to equip pupils with work-relevant skills which are highly valued by employers. Unlike the matric certificate, which focuses mainly on theoretical knowledge,

work-related occupational certificates emphasise practical skills and hands-on experience, making pupils job-ready from the outset.



"One of the most significant advantages of occupational certificates is their accessibility," says Makubalo.

"Pupils can earn these qualifications without needing a matric certificate, opening up educational and career opportunities to a broader segment of the population. These certificates are structured to accommodate

different National Qualifications Framework [NQF] levels, ensuring that pupils can find a qualification which aligns with their educational background and career aspirations.”

Further good news is that occupational certificates are available across a diverse range of career fields, which means that most aspiring pupils will be able to find a good fit for their personal vision. They include the following:

Occupational Certificate: Home-Based Personal Care Worker (SAQA ID 104792)

- This qualification enables pupils to provide personal care to clients in home-based settings, assist with daily living activities and maintain a safe and healthy environment for clients. It also focuses on effective communication with clients and their families to ensure holistic care.



Occupational Certificate: Health Promotion Officer (SAQA ID 94597)

- This qualification prepares pupils to promote health and wellness in communities, develop and implement health promotion programmes and conduct health education and awareness campaigns. It also involves collaborating with healthcare professionals and community organisations to achieve health promotion goals.



Occupational Certificate: Cash Office Clerk (SAQA ID 101863)

- This qualification trains pupils to manage cash transactions, maintain accurate financial records, process sales and refunds, and ensure com-

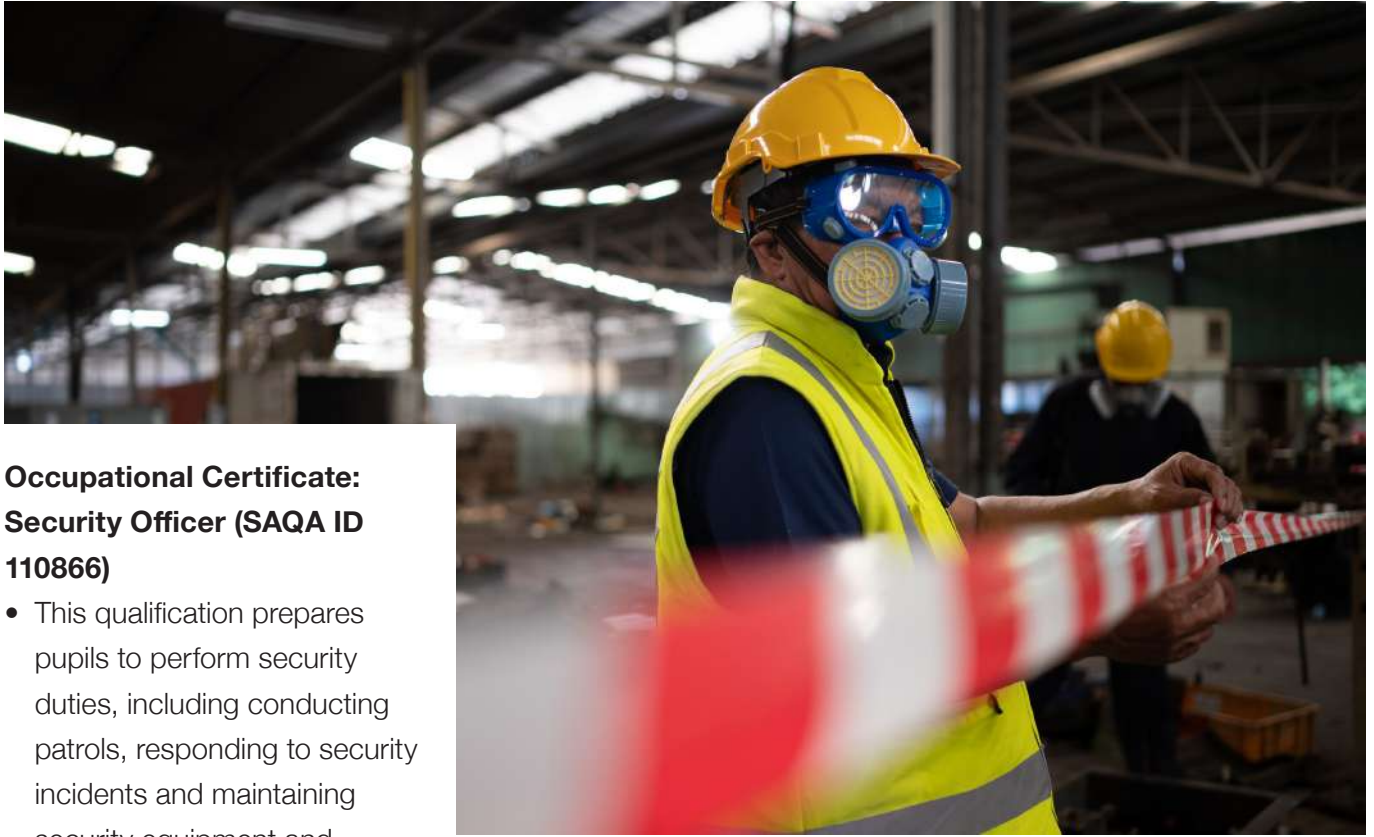


“The reality is that SA offers a robust alternative to the matric route through SAQA-registered occupational certificates.”

pliance with financial policies and procedures. It also includes skills in handling customer payments, managing cash-handling equipment and maintaining a secure financial environment.

Occupational Certificate: Patrol Officer (SAQA ID 110867)

- This qualification equips pupils with the skills to conduct regular patrols, identify and report security threats, and engage with the public to maintain order and safety. It also focuses on maintaining accurate records of patrol activities and ensuring compliance with security protocols.



**Occupational Certificate:
Security Officer (SAQA ID
110866)**

- This qualification prepares pupils to perform security duties, including conducting patrols, responding to security incidents and maintaining security equipment and systems. It also equips them with the skills to collaborate with law enforcement and other security personnel to ensure a safe and secure environment.

**Occupational Certificate:
First Line Security Manager
(SAQA 118687)**

- This qualification prepares pupils to oversee and manage security operations effectively. It equips them with the skills to co-ordinate security teams, develop and implement security protocols, and respond to incidents strategically. Pupils will also learn how to manage security resources, maintain compliance and regulatory standards, and

collaborate with stakeholders to ensure a safe and secure environment.

**Occupational Certificate:
Occupational Health and Safety
Practitioner (SAQA ID 99714).**

- This qualification equips pupils to ensure the safety and well-being of individuals in the workplace by gaining comprehensive knowledge and essential skills to identify and effectively mitigate hazards, as well as minimise risks within designated work areas.

“An overview of these occupational certificates will show that the skills being learnt are in high demand in SA. Additionally, by

virtue of their SAQA registration, they’re recognised and valued by South African employers,” says Makubalo.

“It’s true that a matric certificate remains an important milestone for many, but it’s definitely not the only route to personal and career success. For those pupils for whom matric simply isn’t a fit, occupational certificates offer a viable, practical and work-relevant alternative that will equip them with the skills and confidence they need to thrive in their chosen careers. These alternatives are becoming increasingly important, providing a more inclusive and effective way to prepare youngsters for the workforce.”

Tippie: A unique approach to teaching

What is the Tippie educational series about?

Tippie is about thinking differently about teaching and learning. It isn't a program, but rather a philosophy where we programme for success. Tippie is written by teachers for teachers and it acknowledges that each child is unique.



What was the motivation for creating Tippie? Every child can learn, progress and succeed if “intervention or teaching” starts where the child is at. Children can only flourish if the building blocks for learning are solid, established and generalised. I realised that there was a huge need for developmentally appropriate learning material which focuses on functional outcomes.

This isn't only a reading series – it's evolved into a full-blown educational series. Why the need for a maths series as well? Maths and language/literacy are interlinked. Without vocabulary and comprehension children will

SA Homeschooling chatted to Reinette Lombard, one of the co-creators of the Tippie series, who answered some of our burning questions

also struggle with maths. Most children hate it because they find it dull, boring and repetitive, so we wanted to change their perception of it. Success in maths in the foundation phase is 95% attitude and 5% aptitude. One in 10 children are neurodiverse, but traditional educational materials don't meet the needs of children who think and do things differently.

Level 3 is now available. What can we expect in it?

Level 3 expands on the maths outcomes achieved in Level 2 and breaks down the broad

maths outcomes for Grade 3 into smaller, achievable and attainable ones. Level 3 requires a lot of critical, higher-order thinking and problem-solving, as well as all the “maths” taught in context. It focuses on an extended number range and there's clear progression throughout the series, as well as opportunities for curriculum extension. Tippie does maths differently!

• For further information on all our Tippie products, please visit: www.lala.co.za and <https://curious-readers.com/>.

How to inspire a love of reading in your child

The ability to read for meaning remains elusive for many children in South Africa – and an education expert says that while schools and teachers play an important part in teaching kids how to read, instilling a genuine love of reading is an essential passion which must be nurtured at home before children begin formal education

In SA, the ability to read for meaning is a critical skill that remains elusive for many children. According to the Reading Panel 2030 report, a staggering 78% of Grade 4 pupils can't read for meaning in any language. This alarming statistic underscores the urgent need to foster a love of reading among pupils to ensure their academic success and personal development.

"Reading is foundational to learning and personal growth. It enhances vocabulary, improves comprehen-



sion and stimulates imagination. Moreover, reading is linked to better academic performance across all subjects. For SA, where educational disparities are significant, promoting reading can be a powerful tool to bridge the gap and empower future generations,” says Kassandra Strydom, Academic Advisor: Foundation Phase at ADvTECH.

Strydom emphasises that in a world dominated by social media and mobile devices, maintaining a child’s interest in reading can be challenging. However, she underscores that this is a vital responsibility for parents.

“By integrating reading into daily life from a young age and making it an enjoyable activity, parents can help their children develop a lifelong love of reading, thereby improving their prospects of personal and academic achievement,” she says.

She explains that this can be done by:

- **Creating a reading-friendly environment and leading by example** Second-hand books are often very affordable and libraries are free, making it easy for families to fill their homes with a diverse selection that caters to their child’s interests and reading level. Choosing books together can be a fun and exciting activity,



providing valuable parent-child bonding time. Once the books have been selected, engaging in paired or shared reading experiences

can enhance this connection. Creating opportunities to read together in a relaxed and intimate setting makes reading feel special. This not only fosters a love of reading, but also connects the activity to positive emotions and quality time spent together.

- **Using technology wisely**

To balance screen time at home, families can implement “reading time-outs” that benefit both child and parent. While there are numerous reading apps and platforms which can make reading engaging, it’s important to choose those that offer personal learning pathways, allowing children to explore content beyond just reading. These apps can foster deeper engagement with reading

material by connecting it to real-world situations and encouraging critical thinking. However, it’s essential to also incorporate non-screen reading to ensure that children develop a well-rounded love for literature, alongside their digital experiences.

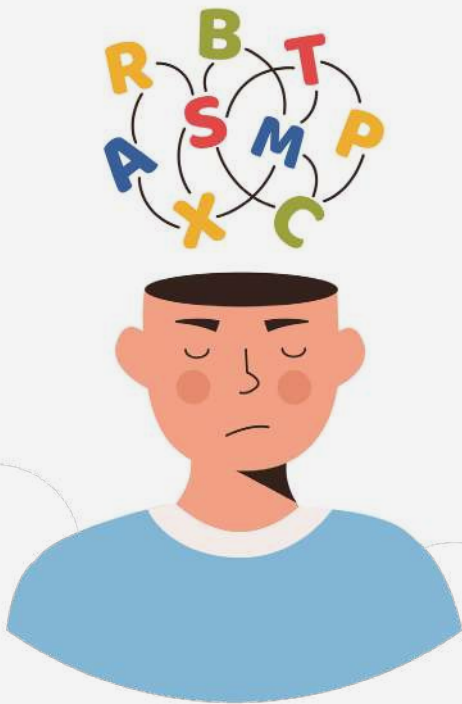
- **Making reading an interactive experience** When fostering a love of reading, it’s important to ensure that the experience is interactive.

Encourage children to engage with books before diving into the text by taking time for “picture walks”, where they can flip through pages and explore the illustrations. This approach helps minimise distractions and prepares them for a more focused reading experience.

“Reading enhances vocabulary, improves comprehension and stimulates imagination. Moreover, reading is linked to better academic performance across all subjects.”



Making writing easier for children with dyslexia



BIC, a world leader in stationery, hopes to change the experience of writing from a struggle to a more pleasurable one.

“Stemming from our vision to bring simplicity and joy to everyday life through our products, and as a leader in stationery, we’re keen to help children enjoy writing – and that includes those with dyslexia. Through writing tools, we aim to make writing less of a battle

Writing should be a doorway to creativity and learning for children, but for many with dyslexia, it can be a challenge

for children with dyslexia so that they can enjoy the process and feel proud of what they create,” says Lillian Henderson, Marketing Director for Southern and Eastern Africa at BIC.

“By designing products that are comfortable and easy to grip, we hope to support them in overcoming barriers and realising their full potential.”

Understanding dyslexia

Dyslexia is a lifelong learning disability which affects roughly 5-10% of the population worldwide, is more common in boys than in girls and tends to run in families.

While dyslexia is rooted in difficulties with phonological processing – trouble identifying speech sounds and connecting them to letters and words, which makes reading a challenge – it can also disrupt a range of other skills, including writing, spelling and even the ability to express ideas on paper.

Dyslexia and fine motor skills

Because many children with dyslexia face challenges with fine



motor skills, even holding a pencil can be a struggle.

If a pen feels too heavy, too thin or awkward to grip, a child might press down too hard, clutch the pen tightly or need frequent breaks because their hands become tired or sore.

This often creates a cycle of frustration: the more their hands hurt, the less they want to write – and the less they practise, the more difficult writing becomes. Over time, this can affect not just their handwriting, but also their willingness to engage with written tasks.

Ergonomic pens and pencils designed with comfort in mind can help pupils who find holding a pen or pencil uncomfortable. As a result, it can be difficult to develop automatic flow that helps them express themselves in writing.

Encouraging a positive writing experience

Writing isn't just about putting letters on paper – it's a way for kids to express their creativity and boost their confidence.

Research indicates that many pupils who struggle with dyslexia also battle with low self-esteem, and negative experiences with schoolwork can only worsen confidence. When kids see their words taking shape without sore hands or smudged lines, it gives



them a genuine sense of pride and accomplishment. This can be just what they need to keep trying, even when writing feels difficult.

A brighter future with the right tools

The right stationery can make a world of difference for kids, especially those with dyslexia. By providing tools that reduce discomfort, many brands, including BIC, are helping kids where it counts – making writing less of a physical struggle so that they can put their energy into learning, growing and expressing their thoughts.

“Writing isn’t just about putting letters on paper – it’s a way for kids to express their creativity and boost their confidence.”



Raising a self-regulated learner



If there's one skill that can set a child up for lifelong success, it's taking charge of their own learning. Dalena van der Westhuizen, cognitive development specialist, executive function skills coach and co-founder of BrainAbility, explains what a parent can do to help their child learn to regulate their own learning

Whether your child's six or 16, and in traditional schooling or homeschooling, the ability to plan, monitor and adjust their approach to learning can make all the difference. This skill, known as self-regulated learning (SRL), helps children stay motivated, overcome challenges and become independent thinkers who can navigate the demands of both academics and life with confidence.

What is SRL?

SRL is the process of actively managing one's learning by setting goals, planning strategies, monitoring progress and adapting as needed. Children who develop SRL skills don't just study harder, but smarter. They understand how they learn best, take responsibility for their progress and develop resilience when faced with setbacks.

The good news? SRL isn't an inborn talent. With the right

support, it's a skill that can be developed and strengthened over time.

The building blocks of SRL

1 Goal-setting: The power of a clear target

Children need to know what they're working towards. However, vague goals like "I want to get better at maths" don't provide much direction. Instead, encourage specific, measurable goals, such as: "I'll practise multiplication for 15 minutes every day this week." Having clear targets helps children stay focused and motivated, while allowing them to track progress and celebrate small wins along the way.

2 Planning and organisation: Working smarter, not harder

Good students don't just dive in – they plan ahead. Effective planning includes breaking tasks into manageable chunks, prioritising work and setting up a productive study space. Parents can help by teaching



children how to use checklists, planners or even simple routines to structure their study time. A well-organised approach reduces stress and boosts confidence.

3 *Monitoring and reflection: Learning to think about thinking*

One of the most powerful SRL habits is self-monitoring – teaching children to ask themselves questions like “Am I understanding this?” or “Is this study method working for me?” Reflection helps them recognise what’s effective and where they might need to adjust their approach. Journaling, discussing challenges or even reviewing mistakes can turn setbacks into valuable learning experiences.

4 *Managing emotions and motivation: Staying engaged through ups and downs*

A key part of self-regulation is managing emotions and staying motivated even when things get tough. Encouraging a mindset where mistakes are seen as opportunities to learn can help children develop resilience. Simple strategies like positive self-talk (“I can improve with practice”) or breaking tasks into smaller steps can prevent frustration from turning into discouragement.

5 *Adapting strategies: Finding what works best*

Successful students are flexible

students. Sometimes a learning approach that worked in one situation may not be effective in another. Self-regulated learners recognise when they need to try a different method, whether it’s rereading a difficult passage, watching an educational video or seeking help from a teacher. Encouraging children to experiment with different study techniques and strategies, such as summarising information, using flashcards or teaching the material to someone else, builds problem-solving skills and helps them discover how they learn best.

How can parents support SRL?

Helping your child develop SRL skills doesn’t mean doing the work for them. It means guiding and supporting them in building independence. Here are some practical ways to do that at home:

- **Encourage self-reflection:** Instead of simply asking: “Did you do your homework?”, try asking: “What was the most interesting thing you learnt today?” This shifts the focus from task completion to deeper thinking.
- **Allow mistakes to be learning opportunities:** Resist the urge to correct every error immediately. Giving children the chance to problem-solve on their own fosters resilience and critical thinking.
- **Teach time management and self-discipline:** Breaking tasks into smaller steps, setting

realistic deadlines and taking regular breaks can improve focus and prevent procrastination.

The “plan-do-review” method: A practical exercise for building SRL at home

Before starting homework or a study session, have your child:

- **Plan:** Identify what needs to be done and set a (realistic) goal.
- **Do:** Work on the task while self-monitoring (eg checking understanding, adjusting focus).
- **Review:** Reflect on what worked well and what could be improved for next time.

This structured approach fosters independent learning and continuous improvement. It also encourages self-awareness and problem-solving, helping children take ownership of their learning journey.

The long-term impact

Developing SRL habits isn’t just about academic success – it’s about equipping children with lifelong skills such as problem-solving, resilience and adaptability. While these skills take time to build, the small, consistent efforts you make today can lead to significant benefits in the future.

By fostering independence, curiosity and a love of learning, you’re giving your child a gift that extends far beyond the classroom.

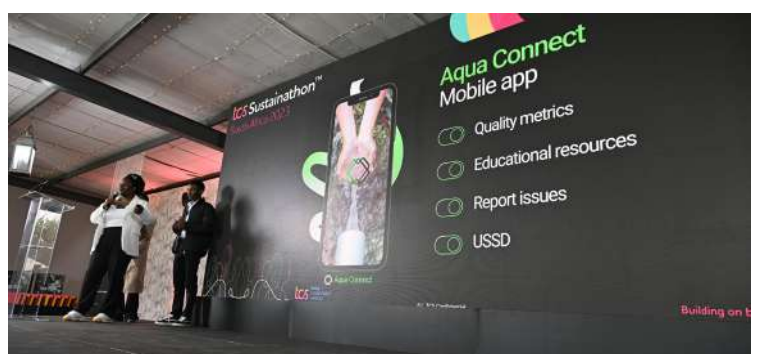


Empowering sustainable youth innovation



To solve the world's climate challenges, we must unlock the passion and innovative thinking of the youth, writes Bronwen Rohland, Retail Segment Head: Africa, Tata Consultancy Services. A global tech and sustainability challenge seeks to do just that

As we welcome 2025 and step one more year into the future, the importance of sustainability and understanding climate change is more relevant than ever before, says Rohland. The youth, who'll be forced to live with the devastating impacts of climate change, are also the ones with the greatest motivation to fix it. However, they seldom have ac-



cess to the levers of investment, development and policy-making that can move the needle for sustainable innovation. They should therefore be empowered not only to come up with ideas, but to implement them.

TCS Sustainathon is an innovative challenge which encourages the youth to engage in real-world sustainability issues and to leverage technology to solve them. It provides a platform to find solutions to sustainability challenges in their own community, while receiving mentorship and guidance from TCS experts, private enterprises, non-profit organisations and government agencies. The third edition of TCS Sustainathon South Africa was recently launched, inspired by UN Sustainable Development Goal 7, “Clean and Affordable Energy”. This theme is especially relevant in Africa, where around 600 million people (43% of the continent’s population) lack access to electricity. Our competition emphasises the need for realistic, practical solutions for real-world issues. The idea is to enable the convergence of ideas and technology for the good of society.

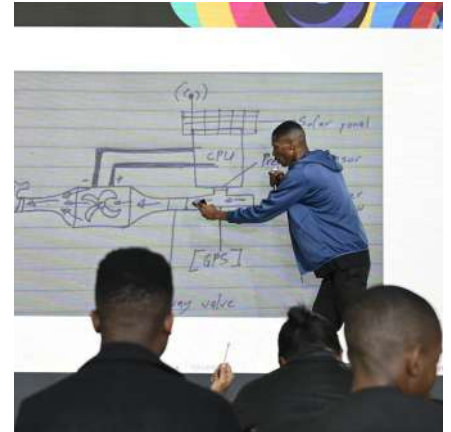
For Africa, the challenge is to overcome energy poverty and to give young people access to the fuel and electricity required to start businesses, power households and drive



development. However, this must be done while transitioning to lower-carbon energy sources and preserving careers within the new energy economy. This need is especially urgent in SA, where per capita greenhouse-gas emissions are already above the global average, energy demand is growing and we still derive around 80% of our electrical energy from coal.

“It provides a platform to find solutions to sustainability challenges in their own community”

Many experts have said that the key to the new energy dispensation is to find smaller, localised energy solutions. Another approach is to improve the efficiency of energy use within the household and the commercial sector. A third way



is to develop forms of energy generation that minimise carbon emissions. Whichever combination of approaches is taken, it will be the young people of the world who build those sustainable solutions for our future. Fortunately, there are many gifted innovators who’re well positioned to improve the quality of life for future generations, while minimising our impact on the environment.

Last year’s TCS Sustainathon winners, Team Amanzi Impilo from the University of Cape Town, created a water solution which uses Internet of Things technology to recycle greywater for non-potable uses. In 2022, Team Waste Warriors from Louwville High School came up with a solution to reduce food wastage in South African schools. TCS Sustainathon 2025 seeks to harness this same spirit of youthful innovation to help solve the planet’s critical energy challenges and to preserve a liveable, nurturing environment for future generations.

As your little one grows, their imagination is where they start to make sense of the world, how it all works and the different roles grown-ups can play.

Dr Lisa Lohiser (EdD), Manager of Early Childhood Development Research at the Fisher-Price Play Lab and mom of two, has a ton of Frequent Flyer miles to the land of make-believe. However, in case it's been a while since you've visited there, here's what you can expect as your little one grows, as well as some tips to help spark their imagination.

Why is pretend play important?

Pretend play lets toddlers explore the world around them in the comfort and wonder of their imagination. They can pretend to be a farmer harvesting crops, a veterinarian caring for their stuffed animal or a barista who puts a smile on customers' faces. The possibilities are endless!

As they describe what's happening in their pretend scenario, your toddler's developing valuable language skills that help them speak, understand and use words meaningfully.

Pretend play also encourages self-regulation and important emotions. Kids who have pretend



From babbling on a toy phone to “making” coffee with their Laugh n Learn Barista Set, pretend play helps your toddler learn how the real world works and how they can fit into it

wrestling matches or play similar games are learning impulse control and how to set and respect boundaries.

Most importantly, your little one finds meaning and purpose through pretend play, which helps build their confidence and self-esteem.

Tips to help your toddler get the hang of pretending:

Tips from a childhood development expert





3 Offer story-starters to spark their imagination, such as: “Is your stuffed bear thirsty? Does he like coffee too?” or put on a performance and let your little star run the show.

4 Set them up for success! Toddlers can jump right into using their toys to pretend play, particularly if the toys are miniatures of grown-up things such as kitchens, houses, tools, vehicles, etc.

5 Play with them: Expand your tot’s pretend play skills set by introducing new, more complex stories rich with emo-



tions, language and fun props. For example, you can “go camping” indoors by working together to build a tent, then “roasting” marshmallows around the cosy pretend fire.



1 Expose your child to new places and experiences

to add new tools to their pretend play toolbox. A trip to the coffee shop or camping outdoors can spark whole new play themes and possibilities!

2 Use toy figures to “practise” a big or new event that’s happening for your toddler, such as going on a trip or starting at a new school. Playing and practising will help them become familiar with these situations, so that they aren’t so intimidating.



“As they describe what’s happening in their pretend scenario, your toddler’s developing valuable language skills.”

Student entrepreneurs' innovative approach to uplifting their local communities has won them a spot at the Global Student Entrepreneur Awards semi-finals

The winners of the 2024 pitch competition that saw six of South Africa's top student entrepreneurs vying for first and second place of the SA finals of the Global Student Entrepreneur Awards (GSEA) have been announced.

The GSEA is an international competition that recognises and supports exceptional student entrepreneurs who own and operate businesses while pursuing higher education. Participants benefit from mentorship, media exposure, business services and networking opportunities, both locally and globally. The programme is globally competitive, attracting over 1 100 applications annually, with only the top two South African entrants advancing to the quarter-finals taking place in Pakistan in February 2025. From there, the top three contestants will advance to the global finals being held in Cape Town in May.

Competing with hundreds of other entrants, the six finalists



competing for the option to represent SA at the quarter-finals in 2025 were Penwell Silinda, Siyabonga Mkhathshwa, Navhani Tshikosi, Tumisho Thobejane, Lesedi Monnanyane and Gad Ben-Schachar Schwartzman.

In first place was Penwell Silinda from the University of Mpuma-

langa. He's an information technology student whose business, SMARTD APP, helps revolutionise the way rural communities access essential services.

Reflecting on his win, Silinda said: "This is a huge milestone for our company and isn't just a win for us, but also for the

communities we serve. By joining GSEA, we've been able to gain valuable feedback and mentorship that will help elevate our business to the next level. Today, 40% of SmartD app users stem from connections made through GSEA, proving the power of this platform to transform dreams into reality."

Silinda was born in the rural community of Kamaqhekeza, Mpumalanga. He says his entrepreneurial journey has been driven by a desire to bring change to underserved areas, focusing on innovative solutions



(Above, from top): Gad Ben and Tumisho Thobejane

which fosters economic growth and convenience. With its user-friendly interface and reliable services, SmartD is bridging the digital divide and transforming rural communities into thriving hubs of activity.

Through cash prizes and mentorship, the GSEA was sponsored this year by Founders Foundation. The top three winners received prizes worth over R300 000. These included cash prizes of R25 000 for the first prize, R10 000 for the runner-up and R7 500 for third prize, as well as free legal advice, marketing strategies, airtime vouchers and much more.

The top 10 finalists from around SA have been paired with EO mentors who are experts in their fields and/or run US\$1 million businesses, namely Nicola Nel, Muhammed Seedat and Thokozani Nhlapo. All the finalists will also receive prizes sponsored by LAMY Pens, Promobasket, DigiCape, The Networking Company and others.



"The programme's focus on empowering change-makers aligns well with the innovative spirit of South African entrepreneurs, contributing to its success in the region."

that benefit society. SmartD was driven by the dream to have groceries, fresh food and rides made accessible to people living in the most remote areas. By connecting local vendors, delivery drivers and customers, it creates a vibrant digital marketplace

The programme's focus on empowering change-makers aligns well with the innovative spirit of South African entrepreneurs, contributing to its success in the region. To learn more about the GSEA competition and participants, visit: <http://gsea.org/>.

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